C2 Speaking

Managing a discussion

Interrupt, hold the floor, bring others in and steer the conversation back, all with natural, tactful language.

At C2 the challenge is not having opinions but managing the conversation itself: getting a word in, keeping your turn, and guiding a group without sounding pushy.

Move	Natural phrases
Interrupting politely	*Sorry to jump in, but... If I could just come in here...*
Holding the floor	*If I could just finish my point... Bear with me a second...*
Bringing someone in	*Sara, you've been quiet; what's your take? I'd be interested to hear what you think.*
Getting back on track	*Coming back to the main question,... I think we're drifting a little.*
Summing up and checking	*So, if I've understood correctly,... Are we all agreed that...?*

Use names and short tags. *Omar, sorry to cut across you* sounds far softer than an interruption without a name.

Common mistake. Using classroom phrases like *I want to say something*. They are correct but sound abrupt at this level. Choose a phrase that signals awareness of the other speaker.

Practice

Write what you would say.

1. A colleague is talking and you urgently need to add a fact.
2. Someone interrupts you before you finish your point.

3. One person in the meeting has not spoken at all.
4. The group has started discussing holidays instead of the budget.
5. You want to check that everyone accepts the final decision.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. Sorry to jump in, but I think it's worth mentioning that…
2. If I could just finish my point… / Bear with me a second.
3. [Name], you've been quiet; what's your take on this?
4. Coming back to the budget,… / I think we're drifting a little.
5. So, are we all agreed that…? / If I've understood correctly, we've decided to…